

What is outcomes architecture and why is it important for all planning, implementation, measurement and reporting?

Outcomes architecture is the way in which a planning, implementation, measurement and reporting system, known in outcomes theory as an outcomes system, is structured. It ensures that an outcomes system includes all the essential building blocks needed for it to be well-formed. These components are set out in the DoView Planning Framework (D1). As shown in the Strategy and Outcomes System Terminology Explainer (D2), many different terms are used for aspects of planning, implementation, measurement and reporting.

Within DoView Planning, someone doing outcomes architecture makes sure that, regardless of what a component is called, it is actually being undertaken for the outcomes system in question. If the organization or initiative is a supplier/provider, any one component might be undertaken by itself, by its purchaser/funder, or by another party. It does not matter who does the component or what it is called, as long as it is being undertaken for the outcomes system in question. In addition to ensuring that all DoView Planning Framework (D1) components are in place, it is vital that these components work together effectively to ensure the system is truly outcomes-driven. the How DoView Tools are Used Within the DoView Planning Framework Explainer (D3) shows how different DoView tools can be used with any organization or initiative to ensure that the different components in the Framework are tightly integrated.

A further key aspect of outcomes architecture when doing DoView Planning is deciding on the make up of the suite of DoView strategy/outcomes diagrams that underpin the organization or initiative's outcomes system. There is often more than one set of DoViews that could potentially be included in such a suite. Someone undertaking the outcomes architect's role is to think through which DoViews should be in the suite that best serve the outcomes system's needs. The most important criterion is that these diagrams should make sense to stakeholders and decision-makers, and they should, as far as possible, be involved in developing them. It is also vital that the DoViews in the suite follow the DoView Drawing Rules (B7), particularly that they are world-centric, not just organization-centric. The suite of DoViews must capture the major parts of the real world "strategy space" in which the organization, initiative, or sector operates and should cover all necessary levels within that space.